

Steven Vanden Heuvel

Principal Designer

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SUMMARY

Principal Designer at PayPal (contract via Magnit Global) from December 2025 to August 2026, working as a product designer on consumer checkout and merchant-facing payment flows for top global brands on weekly sprint cycles. Spent 18 years at MTG Media Group building design systems for 7 B2B brands across responsive web, email, and print. Fintech background spanning consumer finance, financial products, consumer checkout, merchant tooling, and high-stakes payment flows. Build with agentic tooling, Claude Code and Cursor, every day. Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner.

SKILLS

Design Systems, Atomic Design, Storybook, Service Blueprints, UX Design, UI Design, Visual Design, Interaction Design, Product Strategy, User Research, Prototyping, Wireframing, Accessibility, Financial Products, AI Assisted Workflows (Claude Code, Cursor), Figma

EXPERIENCE

Principal Designer, PayPal

Dec 2025 to Aug 2026 | Remote, IL | Merchant Enablement Checkout (Contract)

- Designed a modular one-click checkout flow library for grocery, retail, restaurant, and subscription merchants, mostly mobile, from product selection through payment confirmation.
- Produced 20+ complete merchant proposal packages for PayPal's top 100 global brands on weekly sprint cycles. The program's product manager credited the team with moving top strategic accounts to integration or launch.
- Built the Figma board mapping the checkout dead end customers hit with no working card to pay, one of the most frequent checkout patterns, back to the earlier points where they could have fixed it. Structured it with Claude Code from a director's diagram and gathered screens from teams across the company. The work reached senior leadership and became the template the team now uses to map the next flows.
- On my own initiative, built a Figma plugin that cut merchant flow setup from most of a day to 10 to 15 minutes across the 38-merchant program, now used by the full Merchant XD team.

VP / Creative Director (Design Systems & Web), MTG Media Group

Oct. 2007 - May 2025 | Chicago, IL and remote | 18 years in responsive web, product, and design systems

Led a 6-person creative team across 7 publication brands and 6 responsive web products at MTG Media Group, building and owning the design system for all 7 properties. Initiated the brand-site rebuilds and introduced mobile-first responsive design, Figma, and Atomic Design through Pattern Lab, and began the team's move to Storybook.js.

- **Plate (plateonline.com):** Won 2017 Jesse H. Neal Award for Best Website. Rebuilt as a responsive, mobile first product serving 42,000+ readers with 56,000+ monthly pageviews. 90% of subscribers reported the content shaped their purchasing decisions.
- **Project Blackbird (Plate):** Built an interactive oral history product with a dozen video interviews, original photography, and illustrations. Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee, top 4 nationally.
- **Alt Meat:** Launched a brand, magazine, and website from zero in under 8 weeks as the first major B2B publication in alternative protein. Grew to 22,000 registered users.
- **Meatingplace:** Designed a modern responsive rebuild of MTG's highest-traffic daily news site, where 95% of readers reported taking action from content. The brand was acquired before the rebuild launched.
- Built design systems and reusable design tokens for 7 properties, keeping visual and interaction patterns consistent across editorial, marketing, and sales.

AWARDS

- Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner (the B2B equivalent of the Pulitzer Prize)
- Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee for Project Blackbird, top 4 nationally

EDUCATION

University of Wisconsin-Whitewater, B.A. in Art with emphasis in Graphic Design and Marketing